

# Ballot Questions Context

[Content Reference](#) (context that produced the Content Schemata)

## What MAPLE is

MAPLE is a Massachusetts civic engagement platform. Its original purpose is to make public testimony visible and accessible. The core idea is a virtual public square where citizens, organizations, and legislators can see how others are thinking about legislation and ballot measures. It is strictly neutral — MAPLE does not editorialize or take positions.

## The Ballot Measure Feature

We are building a deep-dive page for Massachusetts ballot measures. The goal is to be a one-stop shop where a user can fully understand a ballot measure — the official record, the arguments for and against, organizational testimony, research, media coverage, and campaign finance and is scaffolded according to user type.

## User Personas

- **The casual citizen** — comes in with low context, wants to understand something that affects their life, needs clear language and a fast path to feeling informed. Doesn't want to do research, wants the research done for them. Future priority — the Overview and scaffolded structure is designed for this person.
- **The engaged citizen** — comes in with some context, wants depth and credibility. Needs to be able to trust the sources, follow citations, and go as far down the rabbit hole as they choose. May be a journalist, academic, policy analyst, or just a highly engaged voter. The scaffolded structure and availability of depth is designed for this person.
- **The organizational advocate** — comes to MAPLE to post their organization's official position and make it visible to their member base and the broader public. Uses the platform as a distribution channel to reach citizens who follow them. Also wants to see who else has weighed in, track how the discourse is developing, and potentially find aligned organizations they weren't aware of. The testimony feature is the primary reason this person is here.
- **The legislator or legislative staffer** — comes to MAPLE to see what organizations and constituents are saying about a measure. Public testimony is normally fragmented and

hard to find — MAPLE aggregates it in one place. This person is not necessarily looking for the policy background, they already know it. They want the public discourse picture.

- **The last-minute voter** — comes in the week before the election, needs the shortest possible path to feeling confident about how to vote. Needs plain language, clear yes/no framing, and trusted voices. A version of the casual citizen but with urgency and even less patience for complexity.

## Design Principles

- **Neutral and Trustworthy:** Nothing should feel like it is pushing a point of view.
- **Scaffolded:** A power user should be able to go as deep as they want.
- **Testimony as First-Class:** Organizational voices should feel prominent and credible.
- **AI Synthesis for Readability:** AI Synthesis is used to help users navigate information. It is embedded throughout as a layer, not a separate section.
- **Visual Language:** Clean, civic, a balance of professional with homegrown.

# MAPLE Ballot Content Inventory

## How to use this document

This is a flat inventory of every content item that belongs on the ballot measure deep-dive page. Use it to fill the content schematic shell. Items have no prescribed subsection grouping — the agent should assemble them into logical sections from the user's perspective.

Each item is tagged by source type:

-  Official info — sourced from government or official campaign filings
-  User-submitted — org or individual testimony posted on MAPLE
-  Outside content — media, academic, research, or legislative database
-  AI synthesis — MAPLE-generated, must show citations and sources

Asterisk notes at the bottom of each section flag items where sourcing requires clarification.

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## Persistent header (*not a tab — always visible*)

-  Measure title (plain language)
-  Measure number
-  Election date
-  Measure type (*initiative / referendum / constitutional amendment*)
-  \*\* Current procedural stage (*signature gathering / certified / on ballot / passed / defeated*)
-  Topic and policy area tags

\*\* Underlying status is official record, but translating it into a human-readable stage label requires a defined mapping. MAPLE determines the display logic.

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## Tab: Overview (*future — coming back to this*)

-  Yes / No vote summary (*AG verbatim*)

-  AI plain-language summary of the measure
-  \*\* Current procedural stage callout with next key date
-  Campaign finance snapshot — total raised YES vs NO
-  Featured org testimony — YES (*surfaced from Testimony & Community tab*)
-  Featured org testimony — NO (*surfaced from Testimony & Community tab*)
-  AI synthesis snapshot — top YES argument with citation
-  AI synthesis snapshot — top NO argument with citation
-  Media coverage snapshot (*surfaced from In The World tab*)

\*\* See note in Persistent Header.

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## Tab: Background & Context

-  Official ballot question — exact wording (*Secretary of State*)
-  AG plain-language summary (*verbatim*)
-  Full legal text (*link out*)
-  What a YES vote does (*AG verbatim*)
-  What a NO vote does (*AG verbatim*)
-  Fiscal impact statement (*verbatim*)
-  Plain language translation of fiscal impact
-  \* Readability score — Flesch-Kincaid grade level of ballot language
-  \* Readability score — Flesch Reading Ease
-  Glossary — undefined or ambiguous terms surfaced from ballot text, defined from official sources
-  \*\* Path to ballot timeline — filing, AG certification, signature rounds, legislative review, final certification
-  Signature counts — required vs submitted vs certified
-  Legislative action or inaction during review window
-  Plain language explainer of how this measure type works in Massachusetts
-  Current state of the law or policy being changed
-  \*\*\* Key institutions and offices involved
-  Prior Massachusetts ballot measures on this topic (*RAG from legislative database*)
-  Related bills filed on Beacon Hill (*RAG from legislative database*)
-  How comparable measures have fared in other states
-  AI identification of essential context for understanding this measure
-  AI-surfaced connections to related Beacon Hill activity

\* Computed metric applied to official ballot text. Not produced by any official body — calculated by MAPLE using standard Flesch readability formulas. Source material is official; the score itself is MAPLE-computed.

\*\* Individual events on the timeline are drawn from official filings and certifications. Assembling them into a readable chronological display requires curation and a defined data pipeline from official sources.

\*\*\* Identifiable from official documents but requires editorial judgment to determine which institutions are relevant to a given measure. Treat as AI synthesis from official sources.

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## Tab: The Case For & Against

-  Official YES campaign committee name and registration
  -  Official NO campaign committee name and registration
  -  Official YES campaign position statement (*verbatim*)
  -  Official NO campaign position statement (*verbatim*)
  -  Endorsing organizations on record — YES (*official filings*)
  -  Endorsing organizations on record — NO (*official filings*)
  -  Elected officials with a public position — YES
  -  Elected officials with a public position — NO
  -  Peer-reviewed research relevant to the measure
  -  Think tank and research institute reports (*ideological affiliation noted*)
  -  Government-produced research or data
  -  AI synthesis of research — what evidence shows, where evidence is thin or contested, citations required
  -  AI synthesis — strongest YES arguments across all sources, citations required
  -  AI synthesis — strongest NO arguments across all sources, citations required
  -  Areas of consensus across sources
  -  Areas of disagreement across sources
  -  Open questions and unresolved claims
  -  Claim mapping — claims made, evidence cited, what is contested
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## Tab: Testimony & Community

-  Verified org testimony — YES position
  -  Verified org testimony — NO position
  -  Verified org testimony — neutral or informational
  -  Count of orgs who have submitted testimony
  -  Individual testimony — YES position
  -  Individual testimony — NO position
  -  Individual testimony — neutral or questions raised
  -  Count of individuals who have submitted testimony
  -  User-submitted questions
  -  Post your own testimony (CTA)
  -  AI synthesis of org testimony — strongest YES arguments, citations required
  -  AI synthesis of org testimony — strongest NO arguments, citations required
  -  Areas of consensus across testimony
  -  Areas of disagreement across testimony
  -  Open questions and unresolved claims from testimony
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## Tab: In The World (*lower priority — sketch lightly*)

-  News articles — Massachusetts outlets
  -  News articles — national outlets
  -  Editorial board positions (*outlet named, YES / NO / neutral*)
  -  Opinion and op-ed pieces (*author and outlet named*)
  -  AI synthesis of media coverage — dominant narratives, notable disagreements, citations required
  -  AI identification of claims in media coverage that are contested or unverified
  -  Polls — pollster, date, sample size, margin of error, YES %, NO %, undecided %
  -  Exact poll question wording per poll
  -  AI synthesis of polling trend (*if multiple polls exist*)
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## Campaign Finance (*tab placement TBD*)

- ● Total raised — YES committee
- ● Total raised — NO committee
- ● Total spent — YES committee
- ● Total spent — NO committee
- ● Top donors — YES (*name, amount, employer or affiliation*)
- ● Top donors — NO (*name, amount, employer or affiliation*)
- ● In-kind contributions (*where notable*)
- ● Signature gathering expenditures
- ● Cost per required signature (*CPRS*)
- ● AI pattern note — funding concentration, out-of-state money, timing of donations  
(*cited to OCPF*)